

Studies in Educational Leadership

Volume 25

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Charles F. Webber

Editor

Teacher Leadership in International Contexts

 Springer

Editor

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Preface

The *International Study of Teacher Leadership* (www.mru.ca/istl) began in 2018 at an invitational international research conference hosted by Dr. Wenji Fan and his colleagues in the Faculty of Education at Guangxi Normal University in Guilin, China. During the conference, several colleagues who had been co-researchers on previous international studies spent time discussing their mutual interest in the construct of teacher leadership. The colleagues agreed to form a core research team and, by the end of the conference, the team had formulated research questions and planned a six-stage study.

Over the next 4 years, the research team expanded its membership until it included representatives from Australia, Canada, China, Colombia, Mexico, Romania, South Africa, Spain, Tanzania, and Turkey, and more recently Morocco and Argentina. The co-researchers began their studies in their respective countries, maintaining their focus through ongoing synchronous videoconferences.

Early-stage ISTL reports were shared at a 2019 conference in Çesme, Turkey, hosted by Kadir Beycioglu, Ali Çağatay Kılınç, Serap Emil, Ahmet Su, and their colleagues with the Turkish Educational Administration Research and Development Association. Professor Beycioglu was one of the original research team members who gathered in Guilin in 2018. He had collaborated previously with several ISTL members on the *International Study of Principal Preparation*. Professor Beycioglu, in his role as Founding Editor of *Research in Educational Administration and Leadership*, also included a special journal issue, co-edited by Janet Mola Okoko, that featured the work of ISTL team members.

Although COVID-19 global pandemic restrictions made some parts of the research impossible from early 2020 until early 2022, the research team was able to adapt by using technology to conduct online interviews, observe online teacher meetings and professional development activities, and administer questionnaires. Our findings were shared during virtual conferences and seminars, due to the initiative of ISTL members such as Edith Cisneros-Cohernour, Pedro José Canto Herrera, and Gabriela Achach Sonda in Mexico; and by Jan Khumalo, Molly Fuller, Corné van der Vyver, and Jan Heystek in South Africa. As global health restrictions gradually eased in 2022, other study stages became possible, such as case studies,

face-to-face interviews, and oral histories. We have returned to presenting our work at in-person conferences and publishing in academic journals.

In the meantime, this book shares some of what the ISTL team learned from its work that was conducted during difficult worldwide challenges. The book's appearance is testimony to the diligence of the ISTL research team, but it is important to note that Kadir Beycioglu was a major force behind our collective desire to produce this book. He planned to serve as co-editor and he began the initial exploration of publication possibilities. Then, Kadir and his family suffered two major blows. Tragically, they lost their young son in a traffic accident and Kadir was diagnosed with a severe illness. His declining health caused him to be unable to begin the editing work that he was passionate about doing. He continued to stay in touch with all of us about the book and to offer encouragement right until he passed away in August 2021. Our international studies of teacher leadership would look very different without the vision and contributions of Professor Beycioglu.

Our ongoing international studies of teacher leadership are possible because of Wenji Fan's vision at the forefront of our planning, the impetus of Kadir Beycioglu, and the tireless research, analyses, and writing of all ISTL members. As with most well-functioning research teams, the ISTL is a collection of excellent scholars who also are friends.

In summary, this book articulates how the research team and study participants conceptualize teacher leadership and how they perceive it is manifested, or not, in Western and non-Western schools and educational systems. The chapter authors also share how the values, beliefs, and assumptions underpinning teacher leadership are reflective of culture and context. Part I describes who is interested in teacher leadership and why it has emerged as a relatively undefined yet influential factor in educational discourses in many nations. This section also describes how the purpose of the ISTL, and this book, is to contribute to the wider understanding of teacher leadership and of how professional developers might contribute to teacher leadership knowledge and skill development. Part II of the book highlights how important it is to contextualize descriptions of teacher leadership and the roles of teacher leaders. Factors such as social context, political frameworks, postcolonialism, and economic well-being determine the degree to which teacher leadership can be a consideration in educational governance, policy making, and leadership development. In Part III, readers are challenged to consider how traditional expectations for educators and the politics of leading may contribute to organizational homeostasis that frequently supports the status quo in education systems. This section of the book also describes schools and school systems as ecosystems in which some teachers and principals stand out because of their profiles as credible and trustworthy individuals. Such teacher leaders influence their communities more than most because of their self-awareness, altruism, and interpersonal acumen.

More to come.

Calgary, AB, Canada
December 5, 2022

Charles F. Webber

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Editor and Contributors

About the Editor

Charles F. Webber is a Professor in the Department of Education, Mount Royal University. He is a Teacher and Researcher who served the first half of his career as a classroom teacher and school principal in Alberta and Saskatchewan, Canada. Following a move to higher education, he has held appointments as a Professor and Dean in Alberta and British Columbia, Canada. His teaching and research interests focus on teacher leadership, the principalship, student assessment, and higher education administration and leadership. He is Professor Emeritus with the University of Calgary in Canada and Buitengewone Professor with North-West University in Potchefstroom, South Africa. <https://orcid.org/0000-0002-8093-5118>
Email: cfwebber@mtroyal.ca

Contributors

Leydi Gabriela Achach-Sonda Universidad Autónoma de Yucatán, Mérida, Mexico

Dorothy Andrews Faculty of Business, Education, Law and Arts, Leadership Research International, University of Southern Queensland, Toowoomba, QLD, Australia

Catherine Arden University of Southern Queensland, Toowoomba, QLD, Australia

Aabla Biqiche Moulay Ismail University, the School of Arts and Humanities, Meknes, Morocco

Abdelmajid Bouziane Hassan II University, Casablanca, Morocco

Edith J. Cisneros-Cohernour Universidad Autónoma de Yucatán, Mérida, Mexico

Joan M. Conway University of Southern Queensland, Toowoomba, QLD, Australia

Mohammed Elmeski The Nordic Center for Conflict Transformation, Rabat, Morocco

Cecilia Fierro-Evans Universidad Nacional Autónoma de México, ENES, León, Mexico

M. P. Fuller North-West University, Potchefstroom, South Africa

Gloria Gratacós Universidad Villanueva, Madrid, Spain

Samira Idelcadi Hassan II University, Casablanca, Morocco

J. B. Khumalo North-West University, Potchefstroom, South Africa

Nour-eddine Laoui Regional Center for the Professions of Education and Training, Meknes, Morocco

Cristina Moral-Santaella University of Granada, Granada, Spain

Jodi Nickel Department of Education, Mount Royal University, Calgary, AB, Canada

Janet M. Okoko University of Saskatchewan, Saskatoon, SK, Canada

Clelia Pineda-Báez Universidad de La Sabana, Chía, Cundinamarca, Colombia

Samira Rguibi Hassan II University, Casablanca, Morocco

Antonio J. Sánchez-Lamolda Santa María Primary School, Granada, Spain

C. P. van der Vyver North-West University, Potchefstroom, South Africa

Pedro León Vivas Universidad Austral, Pilar, Buenos Aires, Argentina

Nicholas Wachira Aga Khan University, Dar es Salaam, Tanzania

Charles F. Webber Department of Education, Mount Royal University, Calgary, AB, Canada